

OFFICIAL POLICY MEMORANDUM & EVIDENTIARY DOSSIER

Kalam Nation First Trust (KNFT) & State Confederation of Waterbody Rejuvenation Volunteers

Ref No: KNFT/PM/VB-GRAM-G/2026/01

Date: June 25, 2026

FROM:
MANIKANDAN N
State Confederation of Waterbody Rejuvenation
Volunteers
Founder, Kalam National First Trust
Villupuram District, Tamil Nadu
Mob: +91-9500804607

TO:
The Hon'ble Minister of Finance
Government of India
North Block, New Delhi - 110001

SUBJECT: Strategic Policy Recommendations under the 'VB-GRAM G' (Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission - Gramin) Act, 2025 to Authorize Mechanical Intervention for Deep Lake Rejuvenation and Institutionalize Public-NGO Convergence Frameworks.

Respected Madam,

1. Context and Commendation

We extend our profound commendation on the recent enactment of the path-breaking legislation—"The Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin): VB-GRAM G Act, 2025". The statute's core mandate focusing on comprehensive "Water Security through water-related works" aligns seamlessly with India's long-term climate resilience framework and national development priorities.

As grassroots conservationists deeply rooted in reviving historical Chola and Pallava dynasty water-management techniques—formally recognized through 'The Tamil Nadu Chief Minister's Water Conservation Award' and the prestigious 'Green Achiever Award' for exemplary environmental governance—we recognize this Mission as a monumental leap toward rural self-sufficiency.

2. The Critical Policy Imperative: Integrating Mechanical Power with Manual Labour

While the visual and socio-economic scale of the statutory wage employment framework is exemplary, a critical operational gap exists on the ground. Under the current parameters, restricting desilting and excavation exclusively to manual labour inadvertently compromises the structural efficacy of major waterbody restorations.

Vast rural lakes suffer from severe topographical degradation, deep-seated silt accumulation, and aggressive proliferation of invasive species like water hyacinth. These complex ecological challenges are impossible to mitigate via manual labor alone, often limiting execution to minor, peripheral channel-clearing.

Strategic Recommendation 1 (Fiscal & Operational Flexibility):

We strongly urge a strategic policy amendment within Schedule I (Section 4) of the Act to officially permit a

mathematically defined, audited percentage of budgetary funds for heavy machinery (Excavators) specifically earmarked for the scientific desilting and structural reinforcement of rural lakes.

[Manual Labour: Peripheral Works] + [Audited Mechanical Power: Deep Excavation]

↓

= 100% Structural Efficacy & Deep Desilting

3. Institutionalizing the Public-NGO Convergence Model for Budgetary Efficiency

The 'VB-GRAM G' Act heavily emphasizes localized, saturation-driven planning through the formulation of 'Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans' and the creation of the 'Viksit Bharat National Rural Infrastructure Stack'. To transform this vision into a transparent, leak-proof reality, the administrative framework must leverage existing civilian expertise.

The Proven Grassroots Model: Our extensive confederation—anchored by the phenomenal execution track record of M.N. Gayathri Charities, Chennai (having successfully rejuvenated over 100 regional waterbodies), alongside the Kalam National First Trust and ExNoRa—stands as a testament to public-led ecological success. We have successfully revived massive eco-systems, including the 39-acre Koliyanur Lake and the 45-acre Muthampalayam Lake.

Strategic Recommendation 2 (Public-NGO Convergence Framework):

We petition the Ministry of Finance to introduce strict fiscal and operational guidelines enlisting accredited social organizations and NGOs with verified ecological track records as official 'Knowledge and Implementation Partners' at the District and Block planning levels.

This institutional synergy will achieve the following critical objectives:

- **Zero Financial Leakage:** Strictly eliminate financial leakages and ensure optimal utilization of central funds through community-driven social audits.
- **Resource Optimization:** Optimize mechanical resource allocation and cost-benefit ratios per hectare of water body restored.
- **Long-term Asset Sustainability:** Ensure continuous post-restoration maintenance (such as large-scale sapling and palm-seed planting initiatives) without recurring financial burdens on the exchequer.
- **Value for Public Expenditure:** Guarantee that 100% of the public expenditure is directly translated into permanent, transformative national assets.

4. Conclusion and Appeal

We earnestly appeal to your esteemed office to review these vital, field-verified policy feedbacks. By incorporating these mechanical and institutional amendments into the operational and budgetary rules of the VB-GRAM G Act, the Government of India will pave the way for unprecedented, globally-recognized water security across rural Bharat.

We look forward to an opportunity to present our comprehensive technical project reports (DPRs) to support this national vision.

Thanking you.

Yours faithfully,

[MANIKANDAN N]

Founder, Kalam National First Trust

On behalf of the State Confederation of Waterbody Rejuvenation Volunteers

ANNEXURE I: OFFICIAL MEETING RECORD

Meeting with Finance Minister

Mr. N. Manikandan formally submitting the Strategic Policy Memorandum directly to the Hon'ble Union Minister of Finance, Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman on June 25, 2026.



ANNEXURE II: PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU (PIB) MEDIA ALERT

PIB Media Alert

Official Government of India PIB release corroborating the Hon'ble Finance Minister's itinerary to inaugurate the 400-year-old Muzhiankulam on June 26, 2026.



PIB

Press Information Bureau, Govt. of India
Soochna Bhavan,
5, Swami Sivananda Salai, Chennai - 05
E-mail: pi Chennai@nic.in | pi Chennai@gmail.com

MEDIA ALERT

Phone: 044 - 28228147 / 48
Fax : 044 - 28226977

PIB HQ Website: www.pib.nic.in

2026/06/24/C/19-Pub

24 June 2026

Dear Editor / Chief of Bureau,
Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman, Union Minister for Finance & Corporate Affairs, Government of India is attending the following events in Puducherry on 25th & 26th June 2026.

Details of the event:

Date	Time	Event	Venue
25.06.2026 (Thursday)	05.30 PM	Inauguration of Renovated Old Lighthouse of CGST Puducherry Commissionerate	Goubert Avenue, White Town, Puducherry
26.06.2026 (Friday)	10:00 AM	Inauguration of 400-Year old Muzhiankulam	Government Middle School Grounds, Pooranakuppam, Puducherry

You are kindly requested to depute your correspondent to attend the event and give wide coverage.

Contact Person Details:

Shri. Sanjay Ghosh
(Deputy Director)
Mobile: 91766 45673

Sd/-
Vijayalakshmi J
Deputy Director

To: Editors/ COB /
crews / Photo Edit.



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ANNEXURE III: OFFICIAL INAUGURATION INVITATION

Official Invitation

Official invitation for the Muzhiankulam restoration event held on June 26, 2026, attended by the Hon'ble Finance Minister, Lt. Governor, and Chief Minister of Puducherry.



ANNEXURE IV: MASSIVE MEDIA COVERAGE & ON-STAGE RECOGNITION

The successful rejuvenation and inauguration of the 400-year-old Muzhiankulam on June 26, 2026, witnessed unprecedented coverage across premier national and state media outlets. The Hon'ble Union Minister of Finance, alongside the Chief Minister and Lt. Governor of Puducherry, officially honored Mr. N. Manikandan and the KNFT/Gayathri Charities team on stage for their phenomenal grassroots execution.

Documented Broadcast & Print Media Evidence Includes:

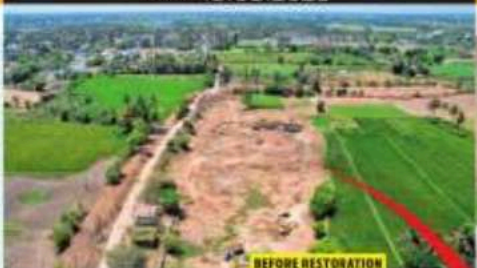
- **The New Indian Express**
- **Sun News (Live Broadcast Coverage)**
- **Puthiya Thalaimurai (Live Broadcast Coverage)**
- **Hindu Tamil Thisai**
- **Daily Thanthi (Dina Thanthi)**
- **Dinakaran & Dinamalar**

Complete video and press clippings of the on-stage felicitation by the Hon'ble Finance Minister are available on public record and have been preserved as digital evidence.

KRITHIKA SRINIVASAN @vivekan

The dust of decades had settled thick upon the promise of Koliyanur lake, a vital artery choked by neglect and the relentless creep of encroachment. For a generation, its lifeblood had dwindled, a silent tragedy unfolding in Villupuram district. But from the parched earth, a spark ignited—the Kalaam Volunteer Group. This unassuming collective of residents dared to dream of reviving it, a vision that would not only reshape their environment but also bind their community in the face of nature's fury. Their story, unfolding over the past year, is a testament to the extraordinary power of ordinary people, a beacon of hope that pierced through the devastation of Cyclone Fengal and resurrected a lost lifeline.

Koliyanur lake, stretching across hundreds of acres, had been encroached upon by 57 farming families in the Koliyanur village area for more than three decades. Once a crucial source of irrigation and drinking water, the lake had slowly shrunk by half due to unregulated occupation and sediment build-up. Recognising the ecological and communal importance of the lake, the Kalaam Volunteer Group, in collaboration with Ecozo International Foundation, NDSO and M N Gayathri Charities, initiated a restoration project in 2024. "As a resident of Koliyanur, I've never seen the river with water since I was a child, and it has been a dream to see it flow with water in its natural state. And that is why I chose to revive it," said N Manikandan (32), the group's full-time organiser. Through persistent dialogue and peaceful engagement, the volunteers worked closely with local authorities and the encroaching farmers to find a resolution. Many of these farmers, though initially resistant, were later persuaded to vacate the land, understanding the long-term benefits of a restored waterbody for



BEFORE RESTORATION

A crucial lifeline decades ago, the 100-acre Koliyanur lake had shrunk by half. Through the efforts of Kalaam group, 37 acres of land restored in 2025

LET THERE BE WATER!

TOES OF CHANGE



The Kalaam Volunteer Group, funded by local residents, has revived the Koliyanur lake, which had significantly shrunk due to encroachment by 57 farming families (above)



the wider community. "The restoration involved clearing vegetation, removing debris, and extensive desilting operations. Volunteers toiled for months under the sun, raising funds to buy machinery and support in the form of machinery and manpower from well-wishers. By early 2025, the lake had been rejuvenated across 37 acres — its banks deepened, banks fortified, and native flora reintroduced around its perimeter. The revived lake has now begun recharging groundwater, benefiting nearby villages, and is expected to support agricul-

ture in the region for decades to come," said Manikandan. The organisation further extended its service to address the devastating effects of Cyclone Fengal in November 2024. Amidst the chaos, the Kalaam Volunteer Group emerged as one of the first responders. Within hours, volunteers sprang out across the district, setting up makeshift relief camps, organizing food drives, and distributing essentials. Several lakhs of people were aided, thanks to the group's network and local knowledge. The group's approach ensured that relief reached not just urban neighbourhoods but also isolated villages and marginalised

communities, including tribal, disabled, and transgender populations.

Manikandan, aged 32, has been instrumental in mobilising and mentoring the Kalaam Volunteer Group's active members. What began as a small effort to support social workers in his area in 2023 has now evolved into a fully-fledged social service network. The group operates with a decentralised structure, empowering young volunteers to take initiative and lead local projects. "Seeing the lake brim with water again brings hope," says M Lakshmi, a local schoolteacher. "Children now learn about ecology firsthand, and farmers have reported higher yields thanks to improved groundwater." Harish, one of the former encroachers, adds, "I was worried about losing my patch of land, but the training provided by Kalaam Volunteer Group helped me understand the importance of keeping water bodies intact for the greater good."

The group's work caught the attention of the Villupuram collector's office, which has since pledged technical support for maintaining water quality and embankment safety. These partnerships promise to institutionalise community-led conservation and enhance policy frameworks for waterbody management across Tamil Nadu.

From the quiet determination to revive a dying lake to the swift and selfless response in the face of a brutal cyclone, the Kalaam Volunteer Group has etched an indelible mark on the landscape and the lives of Villupuram. The ripples of their actions extend far beyond the banks of the rejuvenated Koliyanur, promising a legacy of resilience for generations to come.

(Edited by Divesh Jafferian E)

"The revived lake has now begun recharging groundwater, and is expected to support agriculture in the region for decades to come"

N Manikandan

Trees thrive in her palms



E L Pratheep Jee, a former teacher, giving handmade palm-leaf hats to students at the TAN Palm Foundation established by her in Kanyakumari | @vivekan

N ABUL HADI @vivekan

SWOODS, stirred by the passing breeze, long palm fronds gently grace the rooftops of E L Pratheep Jee's childhood home in the Ettuvai village of Kanyakumari. The village sat nestled among three parallel mountains, woven into the fabric of their daily life. Jee, who reflects playing with nature, sipping mango juice, and sleeping on palm-leaf mats. In her early 40s, she quit her teaching profession and took up a new life mission — to revive the lost glory of the palm tree, a symbol which, she says, is deeply rooted in Tamil community and landscape. The 36-year-old now travels across Tamil Nadu to plant palm saplings, conduct awareness campaigns, and train communities to craft value-added palm products, through her organisation the TAN Palm Foundation.

Fondly called "Pani Maru Thambai" (Palm Star), Jee is a familiar face at social gatherings, weddings, and political events — often offering palm-leaf hats she personally makes. These handmade gifts, which she distributes even to politicians, serve as reminders of the importance of palm conservation. "Palm trees are not just symbols of tropical beauty," she says. "They are lifelines — offering food, shelter, and income to generations of people. Preserving them is preserving our heritage."



Palm trees are lifelines — offering food, shelter, and income to generations of people

E L Pratheep Jee

Jee trains others, especially women, in making palm-based products — baskets, hats, fans, and decorative items — helping them build livelihoods while promoting eco-conscious practices. Though she doesn't come from a family of traditional palm climbers, Jee was raised with a deep appreciation for the tree's value. Her father, P Kizhan, a businessman, and her mother, K Lakshmi, a homoeopathy practitioner, instilled in her a respect for sustainable living.

"Palm wasn't just a tree in our village — it was part of our daily life," Jee recalls. "From what we drank to what we slept on, palm was everywhere." A postgraduate in History with a B.Ed in Tamil and Montessori training, Jee taught at several schools across Tamil Nadu, and eventually worked for over a decade at Pattana Public School in Kottamam, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala. Her hands-on, activity-based teaching style allowed her to weave eco-consciousness into her lessons, including the significance of palm trees. But the pull of the palm was too strong.

Through her foundation, Jee conducts workshops for school and college students, farmers and public. She distributes palm seeds, organises planting drives, and advocates for more plantations along water bodies and coastal belts, where palms can help reduce soil erosion and support biodiversity.

She says the mission is not just about trees, but about reviving a way of life that respects sustainability. "Educating the next generation on the ecological, economic, and cultural value of palms is essential. Only then will conservation become a collective responsibility."

The foundation also showcases palm-based products at community and religious events, and offers free palm-leaf caps to kids and public as part of its outreach. 5 Jee, district convener of NGOs Coach-Tamil Nadu, notes, "Pratheep Jee has been instrumental in raising awareness on palm conservation and promoting the use of palm-based products." F Jothi Anirudha Jee, who joined her in several awareness drives, recalls how she showcased traditional palm products like Anapattai (palm jaggery) and panchamrutham (palm nectar) at places of worship. Another resident, M Jaya, who has known Jee since childhood, says, "She has always had a deep love for palm trees and everything they represent. Her life is surrounded by palm trees."

(Edited by Mary Catherine)

RAJALAKSHMI SAMPATH @vivekan

AMID the bustle at Sathuvachari in Vellore, an everyday ritual speaks volumes of silent devotion. As S Kalaiyandi steps out from her modest home, the familiar sound of paws on pavement follows. Dozens of street dogs, eyes bright and tails wagging, gather around her. This is not just a moment of connection, but a daily ritual of care. For the past 13 years, 53-year-old Kalaiyandi has been a familiar figure in Sathuvachari, carrying food for the 60 stray dogs she lovingly feeds every day. Alongside her husband Sankar, Kalaiyandi runs a modest iron shop tucked in a corner of the neighbourhood — a livelihood they have sustained for over a decade. Though her formal education ended after Class 8, her lessons in compassion began long before, during her childhood in a village where her bond with animals took root.

The turning point came in 2013. Kalaiyandi spotted a dog that had just delivered a litter of puppies beneath a parked car. When the car owner tried to move the animal, she barely flinched — two weeks later to lift her head. "It may sound like just another moment, but seeing her so helpless broke something in me," she said. Kalaiyandi rushed home, gathered whatever rice was left in the kitchen and returned to feed the dog.

That quiet act of kindness became the beginning of a lifelong routine. "My heart feels full only when I feed the strays," she said. Since then, not a single day has gone by without her ensuring that the street dogs of Sathuvachari are fed. Not out of duty but out of love that has not wavered in over a decade. With a family income of ₹15,000 per month, Kalaiyandi sets aside about ₹5,000 to feed stray dogs. Her kitchen has two cookers, of which one is for her four-legged companions. She collects rice donated by kind neighbours, buys fresh chicken, and cooks them with care before pouring into buckets and serving



FRIENDS 'FUR' A LIFETIME

then on street corners twice a day. "Every morning and evening, I pick one spot in the area and feed them there. But sometimes, when hunger gets the better of them, they come straight on my doorstep. They gather around me while I feed them and sit so gently," she said. Over the years, Kalaiyandi has faced criticism and even hostility from some neighbours who accuse her of encouraging the stray population. "Some refused to rent me a house because of the dogs. I understand the concerns around stray dogs, but I can say with certainty, the dogs I feed have never harmed anyone. In fact, they are better behaved than most humans."

Kalaiyandi often rescues dogs that fall into pits or drains, nurses them back to health, and ensures they are vaccinated. Aware of the risks of overpopulation and rabies, she also collaborates with local civic authorities to promote sterilisation and encourages dog adopters whenever possible. "When they are hurt, they come to me. I treat

their wounds like I would my own child. I am not doing this for attention. I do it for the peace it brings in my soul."

Her husband, Sankar, said, "At first, it affected our shop. Some customers were afraid to come in because the dogs would gather near the entrance. Neighbours even fought with us. But one time, I saw her love for them, and I chose to stand by her."

Her neighbour Karjagan said, "Kalaiyandi has been feeding and caring for these dogs for over 13 years. My own children have learned kindness by watching her."

When asked what keeps her going, Kalaiyandi's answer is simple, "I just want to stay healthy enough to feed them for as long as I live. If anyone wishes to help, even a little rice can make a difference."

As long as her hands can carry a bucket and her heart continues to beat with care, the streets of Sathuvachari will never feel lonely for its most loyal wanderers. As Kalaiyandi will be there, doing what she does best: loving without condition, and serving without expectation.

For assistance, contact 9880000000

(Edited by Megha Murali)

"Every morning and evening, I pick one spot in the area and feed the stray dogs there"

S Kalaiyandi

